

by the king's commission and the support of his brothers in Babylonia, and relying upon his own strength and conscience, he did not first consult with the dissenting people he came to govern; he acted and ordered, and things were done; those who disobeyed found it wise to leave his jurisdiction, otherwise they were punished or banished. Rigorous as he was, he seems to have proceeded with greater caution in the matter of the mixed marriages, only forbidding such unions in the future (*Neh.* 10). But the cleft made between the factions of the native Jews by Ezra's course was not healed by the governor. Further he had to encounter the united opposition of the peoples of the lands and their ambitious chieftains, who, along with the self-seeking Persian bureaucracy, had everything to lose if a considerable slice of territory and the fair city of Jerusalem were to be excluded from their control and become an aggressive and arrogant *imperium in imperio*.

We learn the names of three of these antagonistic politicians, and hear much of their ways and wiles. There is Sanballat the Horonite, doubtless of the Gentile colonists in Samaria; Tobia, who was closely allied to the Judæan aristocracy and priesthood (6,17ff; 13,4ff), although himself an Ammonite (2,10); and Gashmu the Arabian (2,19; 6,6). These gentry dared not oppose the Persian governor openly; they had resort to ridicule (4,1ff), or attempts at intrigue and assassination (6,1ff, 10ff). But their chief engine for undoing Nehemia's work was the encouragement of the laxer party of the community which opposed the new order of the day. They became the more or less open heads of the revolt which was simmering against the administration. It was not difficult to find allies; apart from the easily persuaded Am-ha-areç, the Hoi Polloi, they had their long-standing connections with the Jewish nobles and priests, in his disruption of which relations Nehemia appeared to the easy-going ones as a meddle-